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Through the Ocular Lens: Motivations, Meaning, and Impact of Birdwatching

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1. Putting The Birdwatching Subculture Into Context

Birdwatching, often referred to as birding, is a rapidly growing hobby in which people set out to observe birds in their natural habitats. For many birders, certain pieces of equipment such as binoculars, cameras, and journals help elevate the experience by providing the means of closer observation, visual documentation, and record keeping. But while these tools are common in birding, they are certainly not mandatory for the hobby – it is entirely possible to set out birding with nothing but your eyes and an interest in birds. Local parks, gardens, forests, and even one's own backyard can be prime locations for entry-level birding, while those with a stronger commitment to the hobby might travel to other cities, states, and even countries in order to observe a particular species, a practice called avitourism. Irrespective of how one chooses to birdwatch however, there are common motivations for this hobby that are widely shared across the birding community.

The recreational nature of birdwatching lends the activity well to a variety of different goals and motivations, such as meeting individuals with similar interests and building a network (social), learning more about local fauna and leading nature tours (educational), or simply spending time outdoors and appreciating the beauty of birds (environmental) (Janeczko, Randler, Larson). While these common motivations for birding are recreational and leisurely, many individuals approach birding with the more quantitative, research-oriented goal of assisting conservation efforts (Sullivan, Larson). This interest in conservation urges many birdwatchers to do more than just watch birds; it

motivates them to collect data in the name of science research, tracking things like behaviors, migration patterns, habitat usage, and species population among many other factors (Randler, Sullivan, Larson). Projects like these have great potential to assist the protection and conservation of avian species, and it is important to understand how birdwatchers engage with this sector of the hobby.

2. How Birdwatching Contributes to Citizen Science

The term “citizen science” refers to the voluntary research that everyday citizens contribute to larger-scale scientific projects. While there is a variety of existing digital platforms for avian data contribution, eBird, a project by the Cornell Lab of Ornithology and National Audubon Society, is perhaps the most popular among recreational and research-motivated birdwatchers alike. The eBird platform allows its global network of users to input data about bird distribution, abundance, and habitat use to a central data repository, generating a wide pool of useful information that can be used in many realms of formal scientific research. Studies show that not only has the input of data to eBird grown significantly in recent years, but the output of data has grown as well, notably among the scientific domains of ornithology, landscape ecology, computational sustainability, and conservation science (Sullivan). This immense output of data from eBird demonstrates the usefulness of citizen science in its augmenting of formal scientific research.

Additionally, the vast realm of citizen science offers projects of varying complexity, making the field accessible to birders of all experience levels. Beyond digital information platforms which are perhaps the most suitable options for entry level birders, some examples of more complex projects include annual waterfowl counts carried out by official ornithology labs and government entities with the vital help of interested birders, as well as the longer-term bird banding and monitoring projects that can require special training and licensing (Randler). These kinds of projects, through their provision of crucial data about bird populations and the habitats that they rely on, help boost longer-term conservation efforts and species protection plans.

3. The Citizen Science Impact on Avian Conservation

Longer-term bird conservation efforts are ultimately centered around the monitoring of species and habitats that may be under threat, and as illustrated in the previous section, citizen science programs allow for the rapid identification of such species and habitats. Evidently, there is a strong emphasis on conservation within the realm of citizen science; many birdwatchers who volunteer data for citizen science projects do so not with the intent to benefit a stand-alone, temporary purpose, but to bolster the continued efforts to help avian species thrive long-term (Randler, Sullivan, Larson). Bird banding projects for example, are a vital aspect of species monitoring that allows scientists to track things like the spread of diseases, life-span and survival rate, reproductive success and population growth, migration patterns, and the impact of climate change on avian life, all crucial factors in

advancing conservation efforts and developing effective species protection plans. Anyone over the age of 18 and who matches a set of training criteria can apply for a bird banding permit through the USGS Bird Banding Laboratory. Studies show sustained birdwatcher engagement in these bird banding projects, further illustrating the scale of birdwatcher contribution to larger conservation efforts (Randler).

Birdwatchers can engage in conservation efforts beyond the field work and data collecting realms of citizen science; projects in the environmental education sector are equally as relevant in the push for bird conservation. A pertinent example of this is bird identification guides, particularly those that are designed to help hunters identify their targets correctly so as to prevent the fatal shooting of endangered birds that are commonly mistaken for other species. Studies show that degree of knowledge can generally predict conservation behavior, as individuals with greater knowledge of a species are more likely to donate to conservation funds for that species (Lessard). It is evident that understanding public perceptions towards birds is crucial in advancing avian conservation efforts, and these kinds of initiatives to spread awareness for the purpose of species protection provide yet another example of how birders contribute to conservation efforts. Extending knowledge and awareness to a vast audience has the power to ignite a widespread care for protecting avian life where it has previously been disregarded.

As illustrated by the previous discussion of citizen science and environmental education, it is clear that birdwatching encourages public action through both the ecological and the social sciences. And while it has been established thus far that conservation behaviors are common among

birdwatchers, there is more to this conservation involvement than just a mere behavior or act; for many, conservation is a mindset entirely. Many birdwatchers consider the hobby to be more so a lifestyle than merely a pastime, and this higher centrality of birding to lifestyle directly correlates to a higher engagement in citizen science and environmental education (Janeczko,Randler). This makes it clear that emerging from the birdwatching community is a widespread drive for conservation, the scale of which is only growing as the hobby continues to expand.

4. The Gap in the Research

Existing data reflects that the majority of birdwatchers are middle-aged, affluent white men, and while many studies exist regarding the motivations, citizen science involvement, and conservation impact of that general birdwatching demographic, little to no research has been done on these themes within the marginal GenZ and Millennial birding populations specifically. Understanding the younger generations' shift to birding in recent years is important in developing new citizen science projects suitable and engaging for this younger audience, as well as predicting the surge of bold environmentalism that these generations are (and will continue) bringing to the forefront of the ecological fight as it relates to avian well-being.